

Chapter 68_1: Bathed in Fire

Rain pattered down on their heads, into their eyes, flowing into their clothing. The sound of rainwater striking everything mixed into a thunderous roar that, together with the thunder from the sky, made one's head spin.

For a moment, Liu Wenzhu's words could no longer be heard at all, even though her voice was so heart-rending.

Chu Qingqiu stared fixedly at the person before her. Only when water completely filled her eye sockets did she stand up, her pupils moving slightly to let the water slide down both sides of her nose.

"Divine Venerable, the bronze furnace beneath the tiger's den is cursed by vengeful spirits. Only by sacrificing one's body to the vengeful spirits can another be released. I..." Liu Wenzhu cried so hard she could barely breathe. At this time, the others also dismounted from Bai Lin one after another. Seeing Liu Wenzhu kneeling in the muddy water, they were all stunned.

"Wenzhu!" Rong Jin hurriedly took off his outer garment and rushed forward, sheltering Liu Wenzhu, who was still clutching at Chu Qingqiu, under his clothing. He trembled as he said, "What did you just say?"

"Fuyi she..."

Liu Wenzhu didn't need to say more. Her crying could already relate everything. Rong Jin refused to accept such a reality. He stood up and ran toward the crimson swamp in front of them, but was hooked back by Elder Pingyao's sleeve.

"Rong Jin! Do you know what kind of place the tiger's den is? Anyone who enters will surely die!" Elder Pingyao scolded angrily, pulling his ashen-faced form firmly back to her side and throwing him to two Eastern Courtyard disciples to watch over.

Her gaze swept across the swamp submerged in water before them, revealing reluctance in her eyes. Under the washing of the rainwater, this place had become a blood lake, muddy and terrifying.

"Elder Pingyao, this tiger's den is just a cavern. What if we join forces to dig it out!" Feng Ge beside them said urgently.

"Nonsense." Elder Pingyao turned to face everyone. "Thousands upon thousands of vengeful spirits are imprisoned below, each one filled with deep resentment. If they were all released at once, it would be a great calamity for the human world!"

"Then..."

The conversation of several people was suddenly interrupted by one person turning around. That person said nothing, didn't even make any sound, yet it was enough to make everyone involuntarily look toward her, then fall silent.

Chu Qingqiu slowly turned around. Her body was completely enveloped in the heavy rain, her wide robes soaked through by the rainwater, like a divine flower in the rain, its petals swaying and exposed¹, already withered at the roots.

"Go bring Li Zhao'an here," she spoke.

Several Eastern Courtyard disciples exchanged glances and dared not linger any longer. Led by Hong Ying and Feng Ge, they vanished into the night sky.

During the time they were away, no one dared to say anything more. They just stood in the rain, watching the silent Chu Qingqiu. For the first time, they saw such grief and fragility in Chu Qingqiu, as if with just a gentle touch, the petals of that divine flower would scatter in the wind, crumbling into mud.

Liu Wenzhu had already fainted from crying several times, yet stubbornly refused to leave, wanting only to guard this swamp.

She didn't know what she could guard against, but she simply didn't want to leave.

Whether the others thought the same, she didn't know, but perhaps Chu Qingqiu felt the same way, because Chu Qingqiu never spoke again, just standing blankly in the rain, staring at that swamp.

They couldn't wait for anything, but could only wait.

Finally, a commotion broke the silence. Several Eastern Courtyard disciples pressed down a figure that was constantly struggling and fighting as they flew back through the rain. Several people landed on the ground together, immediately splashing muddy water everywhere. The person being held down was still thrashing about with such strength that even the burly Hong Ying nearly got thrown off.

He bent over with a red face, finally tying the Immortal-Binding Rope in a knot to firmly restrain the person.

The one brought back was indeed Li Zhao'an. Her hair, usually braided in small plaits, was now mostly loose, with some of the flowers pinned in it fallen and others hanging crookedly. Her robes were torn—quite a sorry sight.

She forcefully shoved away the Eastern Courtyard disciples still holding her and glared angrily at Chu Qingqiu.

"Why exactly!" Liu Wenzhu could no longer restrain herself upon seeing her. She pushed away those still protecting her and staggered several steps to run to Li Zhao'an's side, slapping her down into the muddy water. "Why did you harm me? And cause Yiyi to jump into the bronze furnace!"

Liu Wenzhu had natural divine strength. This slap nearly knocked Li Zhao'an's head off her shoulders. The people nearby didn't step forward to stop it, all watching as Liu Wenzhu continuously beat Li Zhao'an until she vomited blood.

Only Elder Jingshan stepped forward, seemingly wanting to stop her, but just then black flames suddenly erupted around Li Zhao'an's body. He stopped halfway, eyes full of shock.

Elder Pingyao saw something was wrong and quickly threw out her sleeve to pull Liu Wenzhu back to her side, preventing those flames from burning her body.

"Demonic energy?!" Elder Pingyao shouted in shock. She hurriedly protected all the disciples behind her and turned to Chu Qingqiu. "Divine Venerable, Ning Fuyi was right—it really is demonic energy!"

As soon as her words fell, Li Zhao'an on the ground suddenly burst into laughter. That laughter was sharp and sinister, not at all like her own, making everyone's hair stand on end.

"Yes, I wanted to harm you, wanted Ning Fuyi to be burned by fierce fire! I want her to become a vengeful spirit, trapped forever in a furnace to burn, I want her to feel what suffering is! Not just her—you must die too. Everyone who has caused me pain, I want you all to pay the price!"

Li Zhao'an completely changed from her usual lively appearance, laughing until her features were distorted. She had somehow broken free from the Immortal-Binding Rope and suddenly rose from the ground. Her already blackened treasure sword drew lines around her body.

"Not good, she's already been consumed by demonic energy! Everyone get away quickly!" Hong Ying shouted loudly.

At the same time, the lines wrapped around Li Zhao'an's body in mid-air suddenly burst into black flames, then rapidly expanded like a fishing net made of raging fire. Everything that touched the flames was cut apart and turned to ash at the fastest speed.

Everyone hurriedly scattered and fled, working together to resist this great net. For a moment, various immortal powers mixed with rainwater and flames, throwing the swampland into complete chaos.

Elder Pingyao leaped into mid-air, her meteor hammer attracting lightning to strike at the fire net, finally opening a large hole in the net. She quickly flashed through the gap and urgently called: "Divine Venerable!"

Before her words finished, the white bone in Chu Qingqiu's hand suddenly expanded rapidly, covered from head to tail with a faint white light. At the same time, countless white silk ribbons burst from behind her, piercing through the rain and mist with the swift wind, firmly wrapping around that flame net. The white silk that should have caught fire immediately seemed to be made of iron instead. With an ear-splitting tearing sound, the net was immediately torn in half.

The black flames lost their connection to each other and quickly extinguished in the heavy rain. Seeing this, Li Zhao'an let out a loud shriek. The black energy around her burned even more fiercely. She first spewed thick flames with one hand to block the people coming forward to stop her, then raised her treasure sword and charged toward Chu Qingqiu, seemingly determined to chop her into pieces regardless of everything.

But facing her, Chu Qingqiu stood motionless in place. Her peach blossom eyes, reddened by the rain washing, slightly closed, then opened again, the light in her eyes cold as ice.

She extended two fingers, lightly touching her forehead to draw out a strand of gentle light, then holding this light, she waved her wrist to draw a crescent-shaped mark.

"This is... the Waning Moon Formation?" someone said, looking up and murmuring.

"The Waning Moon Formation was the array Divine Venerable used when she destroyed ancient evil spirits years ago. I never thought we'd be able to see it with our own eyes today!" Hong Ying spoke up, then hurriedly dragged the other disciples backward. "The Divine Venerable is about to cast magic—quickly get away!"

Footnotes:

¹ 露 - This character was partially obscured in the source text with ■■, but based on context it likely refers to the flower petals being exposed or revealed.